Programme Overview

THE 2026 TONY ELUMELU FOUNDATION ENTREPRENEURSHIP PROGRAMME

PREVIEW

Since the launch of the TEF Entrepreneurship Programme in 2015, the Foundation has trained over 2.5 million young Africans on its digital hub, TEFConnect, and disbursed over USD$100 million in direct funding to 24,000 African women and men, who have collectively created up to 1.5million direct and indirect jobs. The Foundation's mission is rooted in Africapitalism, which positions the private sector, and most importantly entrepreneurs, as the catalyst for the social and economic development of the African continent.

Through the TEF Flagship Entrepreneurship Programme, the Foundation empowers African entrepreneurs and the entrepreneurship ecosystem across 54 African countries. The programme is opened to ALL entrepreneurs with businesses within 0 – 5 years. We encourage applications from businesses leveraging AI as well as green businesses.

WHAT TO EXPECT FROM THE PROGRAMME

The TEF Entrepreneurship Programme identifies outstanding African entrepreneurs who have start-ups or business ideas with the potential to grow. The TEF Entrepreneurship Programme will be delivered in different phases as listed below:

1. Application Phase
2. Training Phase
3. Mentorship
4. [illegible]ss Plan, Financials, pitch video Submission and Review Phase
5. Seed Capital Phase

Need Help?

1. THE APPLICATION PHASE

The 2026 TEF Entrepreneurship Programme Application will launch on the 1st of January to the 1st of March at Midnight. Applicants are required to complete the application by providing valid and accurate responses to all questions. Upon successful submission, a notification displaying the applicant's eligibility status will appear on the screen and will also be sent via email. A third party will review applications that meet the cut-off score.

The Application Form

The application form consists of the sections listed below. The personal information section is updated by the applicant or user upon sign in or sign up on the TEFConnect platform.

1. Business idea & Experience
2. Business industry
3. Business acumen test
4. Declarations

To ensure a transparent application process, all applicants must upload a valid government-issued ID that clearly displays their date of birth and photo, as well as a headshot. Also, applicants must update their profile using the exact name on your valid government approved ID card.

ALL APPLICANTS WILL BE REQUIRED TO:
1. Complete all mandatory fields as required in the application form on TEFConnect.
2. Attach all the requested documents (valid identity card and photo headshot) and upload the required documents.
3. Provide valid and accurate responses
4. Ensure to preview your application form to confirm all information you provided is accurate,
5. Proceed to submitting your application
6. Finally, you will receive a notification on screen the TEFConnect platform and via em
on your eligibility to be shortlisted to the next phase of the programme.

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Please Note: TEFConnect can only be accessed using a single email account. It is

important that you create an account or sign in with an email address you will always have access to. Your email address serves as your unique identifier and cannot be changed at any point during the programme.

ELIGIBLE APPLICANTS

When you complete and submit the application form, you will immediately receive a notification on your eligibility status both on the TEFConnect platform and via email. As the next step, your application will undergo a thorough review process conducted by a third-party consultant.

Applicants who are successful and shortlisted after this review will be notified via email and officially invited to participate in the 2026 TEF Flagship Entrepreneurship Programme. They will also be invited to join the TEF Flagship Onboarding Session and gain full access to:

• TEF Business Management Training

• Artificial Intelligence Training

• Green Business Training (for participants in the green economy sector)

Additionally, shortlisted participants will be paired with Business Mentors who will guide, support, and handhold them throughout the programme. It is a key requirement to actively contact and engage with your mentor.

Participants will also be required to:

• Develop a cohesive business plan and financials using the provided template.

• Prepare a 2–3 minute pitch video, which will be reviewed by a third-party consultant.

Finally, all participants must attend the virtual onboarding session to learn more about the programme, its phases, timelines, and receive detailed information on the specialised masterclasses organised during the programme.

INELIGIBLE PARTICIPANTS

These applicants did not meet the minimum programme criteria. We encourage them to continue improving their business skills and consider applying for future TEF and Partner Entrepreneurship Programmes.

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2. THE TRAINING PHASE

The shortlisted participants will receive access to the training content via the TEFConnect platform. All participants are required to read all training materials and complete the

multiple-choice questions to track their performance. In addition, each participant will be paired with a mentor who will guide and support them throughout the programme.

Important: Completion of the training programme is a strict requirement for progressing to the next phase, which includes submission and review of your business plan, financials, and pitch video, as well as eligibility for seed capital disbursement.

3. THE BUSINESS PLAN, FINANCIALS, AND PITCH VIDEO SUBMISSION AND REVIEW PHASE

Each participant is required to apply the knowledge and experience gained during the Business Management Training to develop a comprehensive Business Plan and financials using the template provided by the TEF team. In addition, participants must submit a 2–3-minute pitch video showcasing their idea or existing business.
The Business Plan, financials, and pitch video will be reviewed by a third-party consultant, who will provide feedback and highlight areas for improvement.
4. SEED CAPITAL PHASE
SUBMISSION OF SEED CAPITAL REQUIRED DOCUMENTS

All applicants selected after the application phase are expected to begin the process of registering their business and opening a business bank account.
However, only participants who successfully submit their Business Plan, financials & pitch video before the given deadline will be granted access to submit their business bank details and seed capital documents.
Bank Account Requirements:
ALL Participants from countries with UBA presence must open an account with United Bank for Africa (UBA). See the list of countires below:'
Benin, Burkina Faso, Cameroon, Congo Brazzaville, Democratic Republic of Congo, Cote d'Ivoire, Gabon, Guinea, Kenya, Liberia, Nigeria, Chad, Zambia, Tanzania, Mozambique, Mali, Uganda, Senegal, Sierra Leone, Ghana.

ALL Participants from countries without UBA presence must open an account with a reputable commercial bank regulated by the Central Bank- see the list of countries below:
Algeria, Angola, Benin, Botswana, Burundi, Cabo Verde, Comoros, Djibouti, Egypt, Equatorial Guinea, Eritrea, Eswatini, Ethiopia, Gambia, Guinea-Bissau, Lesotho, Libya,

Madagascar, Malawi, Mauritania, Mauritius, Morocco, Namibia, Niger, Rwanda, Sao Tome and Principe, Seychelles, Somalia, South Africa, South Sudan, Sudan, Togo, Tunisia, Zimbabwe.

Required Documents:

• Government-approved ID card (must be one of the following):

• National Identity Card (Date of birth and photo must be clearly visible)

• National Driver's License

• Permanent Voter's Card

• International Passport

• Business Registration Document/Certificate

• Evidence of Tax Registration (must include business name)

• Bank Reference Letter (The name on the business registration certificate must match the name on the bank reference letter)

• Partner's Consent Form (if you run your business with a partner) and the partner's ID card

• Medical Report from a reputable hospital for participants living with disabilities

Please Read and Note the Following Guidelines

• Ensure that the picture on your ID card matches the image in your pitch video.

• The business name in your bank reference letter, business registration document, and evidence of tax registration must be identical.

• Your uploaded business plan must align with the application submitted and the pitch video.

• If you have previously participated in any TEF or Partner Programme and received seed capital, you are no longer eligible to participate in future programmes or receive funding. Any flagged case of prior funding will result in automatic disqualification.

• Read and comply with the Terms and Conditions and agreements for the 2026 TEF Entrepreneurship Programme.

• Submitting these documents does not guarantee automatic selection for seed capital. It is an opportunity to be considered, provided all required documents are submitted before the stipulated deadline and successfully validated.

• All submitted documents will undergo a meticulous review. Any flagged documents will result in automatic removal from the programme.

Please Review Before Submission- Ensure all documents are accurate and valid before submission.

• The TEF Audit Team will thoroughly review and audit each participant's details and uploaded documents.

• Any participant who fails to comply or submits fake, invalid, or fraudulent information will

be automatically disqualified from the programme.

THE SEED CAPITAL DISBURSEMENT

All participants who have completed all the required steps and whose business bank account details and business documents have successfully undergone the mandatory audit review and received endorsement from the TEF Audit Team will receive their seed capital payment in their designated business bank accounts. In addition, they will be issued a Certificate of Completion and Achievement.

Cancel

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